



in 2019) but right now that's not the case. We (the three Germans) are now starting to get older and more injury-prone and that's why you don't have a lot of Germans at the top right now although we have a young guy Max Dehning who just threw 90m," he says.

"I think Finland had the same problem. They had some really good years and then the older guys ended their careers and then there was like a big hole. Nobody was there who was able to throw really, really far. Now they are getting back. I think it will be the same in Germany."

Not jealous of Neeraj

Perhaps the most unexpected rise in the world javelin though has been that of the Indians. No Indian had even made an Olympic final before the 2020 Olympics. Now Neeraj Chopra is an Olympic and World champion and he alongside Kishore Jena have already qualified for the Olympic games.

According to Vetter, this was a phenomenon that was bound to occur. "There are a lot of talented guys in India. I mean, first of all, you

have a big, big population so there is bound to be talent.. And secondly cricket is a big national sport so there are a lot of guys who will know how to throw. I don't know if that's the reason but I think there's been a lot of improvement," he says.

And while it's Neeraj who's the undisputed leader of the javelin world right now, Vetter isn't envious of the Indian's success. "I don't really compare myself with others. I have a lot of respect for Neeraj's achievements and for his career. But the javelin throw is a very unique event as no one has exactly the same style. I think we are very different both in terms of body type and technique," he says.

While he's gone two years away from the podium in elite competition, and has not even met the 85.50m qualification standard for the Paris Olympics, Vetter believes he can get back on the top. Despite all his struggles, he says his self-belief has never wavered.

"When you aren't successful, you don't always have a lot of people around you but I have a small team who have stood by me; and I've

Searching for inspiration: An ecstatic Vetter after winning the men's javelin throw competition at the ISTAF 2021 athletics meet in Berlin. Despite all his struggles, he says his self-belief has never wavered. GETTY IMAGES

always been very self-motivated. Right now my goal is to just stay healthy. I'm not looking at that (Olympic qualification) number.

"If I can do that, I know I will be able to make big throws again," he says.

He knows he has a few of them still left in him and there's unfinished business too, perhaps even a crack at Jan Zelezny's world record, which he missed by 72 centimetres in 2021. But if he had to choose though, he'd first fill that Olympic-sized gap in his cabinet and resume.

"This year I'm not looking at any number in terms of throws. My first priority is the Olympic gold medal. The last two years have been really tough. I would like to throw far but first I really want to get a medal at the Olympics. It would be much nicer than a world record this year," he says.